



Kiwi-designed Villa Jemma expanded over two levels, with four bedrooms and four bathrooms.

Savour a life of luxury in Bali

Space, privacy and luxury – a villa wins hands down over a hotel for **Caroline Botting's** family holiday to Bali.

This was never going to be an *Eat Pray Love* kind of getaway to Bali. There were two young kids in tow, and my sister's 50th party to host. With little time for soul-searching, we went on the hunt for ease and luxury. The way forward was to switch our rumpty Kiwi bungalow for a luxurious villa.

I'd always wondered what it would be like to enjoy a holiday Posh and Becks-style – jetting off to a far-flung destination, staying in a private hideaway with beautiful beaches, swimming pools, and a personal butler and chef. We were about to find out.

At the last minute, my cousin, her husband and three boys decided to join the party.

Booking a villa in Bali is easy. Within 24 hours we had a three-bedroom place with staff booked through Airbnb – all for a reasonable \$200 a night. Ours was based in the heart of busy Seminyak, once a surfing village, now a bustling beach town.

The area offers a good sample of what drives so many people to visit this Indonesian island – there's a great surf beach, temples, shops, and hip restaurants and bars.

Seminyak is in south-west Bali, 10km from Denpasar International Airport. Don't let the distance fool you. Traffic in Bali is unbelievably bad – narrow roads are often choked with cars so this short distance took us an hour and a half to travel. However, the journey was worth it.

Tucked away down an enclave of private mansions and hidden behind a lush, walled garden was the ultra-luxurious Kiwi-designed Villa Jemma (villajemma.com), which expanded over



The decor at La Brisa beach club Canggu, above, was incredible. It was built using reclaimed wood from more than 500 old fishing boats.

La Brisa had two huge swimming pools, which were great for a day's swimming with the kids.

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The indoor-outdoor master bathroom was so lusciously tropical, my 5-year-old asked if this was where Max from *Where the Wild Things Are* bathed.

A spacious open-air living room extended out to a 16-metre pool and, inside, a well-equipped kitchen was available to prepare meals.

Many villas come with a team of staff – and we were truly spoilt with ours, which included a 24/7 butler.

The staff helped to host the 50th bash on the day

of our arrival, and organised a personalised birthday cake half an hour before the gathering started. They rescued us on a scooter after being stuck in traffic for three hours, booked us tours and restaurants, and fed us a delicious cooked breakfast at the crack of dawn.

Part of the Elite Havens group, Villa Jemma is next-level accommodation costing US\$650 (NZ\$950) a night, but when sharing with extended family, it is more affordable than a five-star hotel, and has some huge perks.

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sinking like dead weights to baby otters by the time we left. While at resorts you can book children into kids' clubs to get some adult time, at a villa it's simple to book a nanny at an extremely tempting NZ\$7 an hour. The Balinese are renowned for their warmth and loving way with children. Our two loved the Balinese nannies who – to be honest – we booked quite often.

Although it takes longer to travel there than our usual Pacific Island getaways, if you can handle the 11-hour flight, Bali is cheaper. We enjoyed a daily \$15 massage, there were \$10 manicures and bargain clothing and gorgeous homewares for sale.

The food was phenomenal – fine dining, fresh juices and heavenly smoothies – all at half the price you'd spend in New Zealand.

The famous beach club, Ku De Ta, was only two minutes' walk away along with the quirky and very cool La Favella.

Ku De Ta is a bar and restaurant filled with incredible vintage finds and antiques set in a exotic, overgrown jungle.

One date night was spent just across the road from the villa at the Samaya resort's Breeze restaurant. We relaxed over a couple of cocktails gazing out to Petitenget Beach enjoying one of



Neon Palms had the best smoothies and mini flatbread tacos.

Fact file

More information:

Elite Havens manages private villas in Bali (elitehavens.com/bali).

Getting there:

Air New Zealand and Emirates offer direct flights to Bali, visit airnz.co.nz or emirates.com/nz.

Tips:

■ As is often the case with little kids in tow, we had a couple of visits to emergency services – a split chin and a red ant bite on an eye. The service at Seminyak's Bali Clinic was great but expensive – it's more than \$100 a visit, so have travel insurance.

■ Getting around Bali is cheap, but taxi prices vary wildly and we found it better to head out on foot rather than face hours sitting in traffic. If you do need to take a cab, hail a Blue Bird – a reputable taxi company. Locals scooter and a great ride-hailing app is GO-JEK – experienced scooter drivers who take you for a bargain of a price at a fraction of the time, and they deliver food.

■ Stepping off an 11-hour flight with kids and into a long queue for immigration is unpleasant, but the good news is, if you are travelling with children 5-and-under you can fast-track your way out.

Bali's renowned sunsets. Other must eats included fine dining Asian-style at Sarong and Sardine, and some upmarket street food at MamaSan. Bikini had great cocktails and fun and colourful Motel Mexicola made us want to stay past our bedtime.

An invitation to join extended family for dinner at the Indonesian night buffet at Royal Beach Seminyak Bali had us eating delicious babi guling – the island's traditional dish of suckling pig.

We'd often venture out in the mornings with the kids as it was cooler, but footpaths in Bali are few and far between so be prepared for some challenges. Memorable breakfasts out were spent at Sisterfields, Revolver and Neon Palms – all offering delicious smoothie bowls, with great interior decor to enjoy.

Villa Jemma staff helped us book drivers for day trips away. This is a great way to get around for longer journeys and cost around \$50 for eight hours.

We ventured out on several trips, including to the Ubud Monkey Forest. We'd heard the horror stories of vicious monkey attacks but it seemed they're mainly in pursuit of food.

We stopped at the scenic Tegalang Rice Terrace, and Satri Coffee Plantation where Luwak coffee is produced. The kids thought it was hilarious to discover the prized coffee beans had to be collected from the manure of the civet, a wild cat in Bali.

Bali is renowned for beach clubs and a highlight was a day spent at La Brisa, in Canggu (an area also worth exploring), 20 minutes' drive from Seminyak. On the shore at Echo Beach, it was like spending the day on a rustic shipwreck.

At Artotel Beach Club, Sanur, we spent the day dipping in and out of the water at a beautiful white-sand beach – perfect for small kids.

As much as we loved exploring, it was always a pleasure to walk through the door to our peaceful oasis and it was tough to say goodbye to the luxuries we quickly became used to.

The writer was hosted by Elite Havens.